"I say, stop it! Please, do stop!" Amazed, everybody turned around, even Mahesh opened his eyes a crack which he had shut in fright. Then the petite Ms. English rose from her seat and spoke to Justice Mathematics in a firm voice, "I don't mean to interrupt, Your Honour, it is just that I feel that everyone deserves a second chance and, after all, this is Mahesh's first offence, he deserves a little consideration."

Mahesh looked at her in admiration, he could have hugged her! She was the one who had been treated most shamefully by him and look at her! Standing so **staunchly** by him! The others too saw reason and slowly backed off, agreeing to give Mahesh a second chance, "Mahesh, see that you never ill-treat a book again!" was Justice Mathematics' parting shot.

"Mahesh! Mahesh!" a hand started to shake him and he jumped.

Had the others changed their minds about not punishing him?

"Oh! Mahesh, do get up. You will be late for school!"

Slowly Mahesh opened his eyes.

Why! He was in his bed!

Yes! There was the battered bag on the floor, the books, half on the floor and others stuffed in the bag. But what was this? The English book was lying near his pillow and seemed to smile at him! Mahesh's mother was **astonished** to see him rushing through the **chores** and then sitting down to glue and cover his English book that very morning! Next year Mahesh Kumar got the prize for the 'BestLooked-After Books'.

- Madhumita Gupta

GLOSSARY

wreck	- worn out	anticipation	- expectation or hope
stentorian	- extremely loud	menacingly	- threateningly
battered	- damaged	frantically	- in an uncontrolled manner
pock-marked	- scarred	staunchly	- faithfully
ponderous	- dull and lacking grace	astonished	- amazed
lumbered	- walked or moved clumsily	chores	- a routine duty or task
verdict	- a judgement or opinion	bedraggled	- untidy or messy
agitated	- troubled emotionally		

A. Read the story again and fill in the table with the present condition of the characters given below.

Ms. English	
Mr. School Bag	
The young Master Notebook	
Mr. Pencil Box	
Mr. Geography	

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